

‘Why not?’ replied Fouquet; ‘if true, as it is said to be, that the king has made him his intendant?’ Scarcely had Fouquet uttered these words, with a marked intention, than an explosion broke forth among the guests.

‘The miser!’ said one.

‘The mean, pitiful fellow!’ said another.

‘The hypocrite!’ said a third.

Pélisson exchanged a meaning look with Fouquet. ‘Messieurs,’ said he, ‘in truth we are abusing a man whom no one knows: it is neither charitable nor reasonable; and here is monsieur le surintendant, who, I am sure, agrees with me.’

‘Entirely,’ replied Fouquet. ‘Let the fat fowls of M. Colbert alone; our business to-day is with the faisans truffés of M. Vatel.’ This speech stopped the dark cloud which was beginning to throw its shade over the guests. Gourville succeeded so well in animating the poets with the vin de Joigny; the Abbé, intelligent as a man who stands in need of his host’s money, so enlivened the financiers and the men of the sword, that, amidst the vapours of this joy and the noise of conversation, inquietudes disappeared completely. The will of Cardinal Mazarin was the text of the conversation at the second course and dessert; then Fouquet ordered bowls of sweetmeats and fountains of liquor to be carried into the salon adjoining the gallery. He led the way thither, conducting by the hand a lady, the queen, by his preference, of the evening. The musicians then supped, and the promenades in the gallery and the gardens commenced, beneath a spring sky, mild and flower-scented. Pélisson then approached the superintendent, and said: ‘Something troubles monseigneur?’

‘Greatly,’ replied the minister; ‘ask Gourville to tell you what it is.’ Pélisson, on turning round, found La Fontaine treading upon his heels. He was obliged to listen to a Latin verse, which the poet had composed upon Vatel. La Fontaine had, for an hour, been scanning this verse in all corners, seeking some one to pour it out upon advantageously. He thought he had caught Pélisson, but the latter escaped him; he turned towards Sorel, who had, himself, just composed a quatrain in honour of the supper, and the Amphitryon. La Fontaine in vain endeavoured to gain attention to his verses; Sorel wanted to obtain a hearing for his quatrain. He was obliged to retreat before M. le Comte de Charost, whose arm Fouquet had just taken. L’Abbé Fouquet perceived that the poet,

absent-minded, as usual, was about to follow the two talkers; and he interposed. La Fontaine seized upon him, and recited his verses. The Abbé, who was quite innocent of Latin, nodded his head, in cadence, at every roll which La Fontaine impressed upon his body, according to the undulations of the dactyls and spondees. While this was going on, behind the confiture-basins, Fouquet related the event of the day to his son-in-law, M. de Charost. ‘We will send the idle and useless to look at the fireworks,’ said Pélisson to Gourville, ‘whilst we converse here.’

‘So be it,’ said Gourville, addressing four words to Vatel. The latter then led towards the gardens the major part of the beaux, the ladies and the charterers, whilst the men walked in the gallery, lighted by three hundred wax-lights, in the sight of all; the admirers of fireworks all ran away towards the garden. Gourville approached Fouquet, and said: ‘Monsieur, we are here.’

‘All?’ said Fouquet.

‘Yes,—count.’ The superintendent counted; there were eight persons. Pélisson and Gourville walked arm in arm, as if conversing upon vague and frivolous subjects. Sorel and two officers imitated them, and in an opposite direction. The Abbé Fouquet walked alone. Fouquet, with M. de Charost, walked as if entirely absorbed in the conversation of his son-in-law. ‘Messieurs,’ said he, ‘let no one of you raise his head as he walks, or appear to pay attention to me; continue walking, we are alone, listen to me.’

A perfect silence ensued, disturbed only by the distant cries of the joyous guests, from the groves whence they beheld the fireworks. It was a whimsical spectacle this, of these men walking in groups, as if each one was occupied about something, whilst lending attention really only to one amongst them, who, himself, seemed to be speaking only to his companion. ‘Messieurs,’ said Fouquet, ‘you have, without doubt, remarked the absence of two of my friends this evening, who were with us on Wednesday. For God’s sake, Abbé, do not stop,—it is not necessary to enable you to listen; walk on, carrying your head in a natural way, and as you have excellent sight, place yourself at the window, and if any one returns towards the gallery, give us notice by coughing.’

The Abbé obeyed.

'I have not observed their absence,' said Pélisson, who, at this moment, was turning his back to Fouquet, and walking the other way.

'I do not see M. Lyodot,' said Sorel, 'who pays me my pension.'

'And I,' said the Abbé, at the window, 'do not see M. d'Eymerys, who owes me eleven hundred livres from our last game of brelan.'

'Sorel,' continued Fouquet, walking bent, and gloomily, 'you will never receive your pension any more from M. Lyodot; and you, Abbé, will never be paid you eleven hundred livres by M. d'Eymerys; for both are doomed to die.'

'To die!' exclaimed the whole assembly, arrested, in spite of themselves, in the comedy they were playing, by that terrible word.

'Recover yourselves, messieurs,' said Fouquet, 'for perhaps we are watched—I said: to die!'

'To die!' repeated Pélisson; 'what, the men I saw six days ago, full of health, gayety, and the spirit of the future! What then is man, good God! that disease should thus bring him down all at once!'

'It is not a disease,' said Fouquet.

'Then there is a remedy,' said Sorel.

'No remedy. Messieurs de Lyodot and D'Eymerys are on the eve of their last day.'

'Of what are these gentlemen dying, then?' asked an officer.

'Ask of him who kills them,' replied Fouquet.

'Who kills them? Are they being killed, then?' cried the terrified chorus. 'They do better still; they are hanging them,' murmured Fouquet, in a sinister voice, which sounded like a funeral knell in that rich gallery, splendid with pictures, flowers, velvet, and gold. Involuntarily every one stopped; the Abbé quitted his window; the first fuses of the fireworks began to mount above the trees. A prolonged cry from the gardens attracted the superintendent to enjoy the spectacle. He drew near to a window, and his friends placed themselves behind him, attentive to his least wish. 'Messieurs,' said he, 'M. Colbert has caused to be arrested, tried and will execute my two friends; what does it become me to do?'

'Mordieu!' exclaimed the Abbé, the first one to speak, 'run M. Colbert through the body.'

'Monseigneur,' said Pélisson, 'you must speak to his majesty.'

'The king, my dear Pélisson, himself signed the order for the execution.'

Chapter LVII

The Gallery of Saint-Mande



LEFTY persons were waiting for the superintendent. He did not even take the time to place himself in the hands of his valet de chambre for a minute, but from the perron went straight into the premier salon. There his friends were assembled in full chat. The intendant was about to order supper to be served, but, above all, the Abbé Fouquet watched for the return of his brother, and was endeavouring to do the honours of the house in his absence. Upon the arrival of the superintendent, a murmur of joy and affection was heard; Fouquet, full of affability, good humour, and munificence, was beloved by his poets, his artists, and his men of business. His brow, upon which his little court read, as upon that of a god, all the movements of his soul, and thence drew rules of conduct,—his brow, upon which affairs of state never impressed a wrinkle, was this evening paler than usual, and more than one friendly eye remarked that pallor. Fouquet placed himself at the head of the table, and presided gayly during supper. He recounted Vatel's expedition to La Fontaine, he related the history of Menneville and the skinny fowl to Pélisson, in such a manner that all the table heard it. A tempest of laughter and jokes ensued, which was only checked by a serious and even sad gesture from Pélisson. The Abbé Fouquet, not being able to comprehend why his brother should have led the conversation in that direction, listened with all his ears, and sought in the countenance of Gourville, or in that of his brother, an explanation which nothing afforded him. Pélisson took up the matter:—'Did they mention M. Colbert, then?' said he.

‘Gourville!’

‘Beware! once at the Louvre, you will be forced to defend your friends openly; that is to say, to make a profession of faith; or you will be forced to abandon them irrevocably.’

‘Never!’

‘Pardon me;—the king will propose the alternative to you, rigorously, or else you will propose it to him yourself.’

‘That is true.’

‘That is the reason why conflict must be avoided. Let us return to Saint-Mande, monseigneur.’

‘Gourville, I will not stir from this place, where the crime is to be carried out, where my disgrace is to be accomplished; I will not stir, I say, till I have found some means of combating my enemies.’

‘Monseigneur,’ replied Gourville, ‘you would excite my pity, if I did not know you for one of the great spirits of this world. You possess a hundred and fifty millions, you are equal to the king in position, and a hundred and fifty millions his superior in money. M. Colbert has not even had the wit to have the will of Mazarin accepted. Now, when a man is the richest person in a kingdom, and will take the trouble to spend the money, if things are done he does not like, it is because he is a poor man. Let us return to Saint-Mande, I say.’

‘To consult with Pélisson?—we will.’

‘No, monseigneur, to count your money.’

‘So be it,’ said Fouquet, with angry eyes;—‘yes, yes, to Saint-Mande!’ He got into his carriage again, and Gourville with him. Upon their road, at the end of the Faubourg Saint-Antoine, they overtook the humble equipage of Vatel, who was quietly conveying home his vin de Joigny. The black horses, going at a swift pace, alarmed, as they passed, the timid hack of the maître d’hôtel, who, putting his head out at the window, cried, in a fright, ‘Take care of my bottles!’

‘Well!’ said the Comte de Charost, ‘the execution must not take place, then, that is all.’

‘Impossible,’ said Gourville, ‘unless we could corrupt the jailers.’

‘Or the governor,’ said Fouquet.

‘This might the prisoners might be allowed to escape.’

‘Which of you will take charge of the transaction?’

‘I,’ said the Abbé, ‘will carry the money.’

‘And I,’ said Pélisson, ‘will be the bearer of the words.’

‘Words and money,’ said Fouquet, ‘five hundred thousand livres to the governor of the conciergerie that is sufficient; nevertheless, it shall be a million, if necessary.’

‘A million!’ cried the Abbé; ‘why, for less than half, I would have half Paris sacked.’

‘There must be no disorder,’ said Pélisson. ‘The governor being gained, the two prisoners escape; once clear of the fangs of the law, they will call together the enemies of Colbert, and prove to the king that his young justice, like all other monstrosities, is not infallible.’

‘Go to Paris, then, Pélisson,’ said Fouquet, ‘and bring hither the two victims; to-morrow we shall see.’

Gourville gave Pélisson the five hundred thousand livres. ‘Take care the wind does not carry you away,’ said the Abbé; ‘what a responsibility. *Peste!* Let me help you a little.’

‘Silence!’ said Fouquet, ‘somebody is coming. Ah! the fireworks are producing a magical effect.’ At this moment a shower of sparks fell rustling among the branches of the neighbouring trees. Pélisson and Gourville went out together by the door of the gallery; Fouquet descended to the garden with the five last plotters.

'Vatel,' cried Fouquet, pressing the hand of his maître d'hôtel, 'you are a man! I thank you, Vatel, for having understood that at my house M. de la Fontaine, M. Conrart, and M. Loret are as great as dukes and peers, as great as princes, greater than myself. Vatel, you are a good servant, and I double your salary.'

Vatel did not even thank his master, he merely shrugged his shoulders a little, murmuring this superb sentiment: 'To be thanked for having done one's duty is humiliating.'

'He is right,' said Gourville, as he drew Fouquet's attention, by a gesture, to another point. He showed him a low-built tumbrel, drawn by two horses, upon which rocked two strong gibbets, bound together, back to back, by chains, whilst an archer, seated upon the cross-beam, suffered, as well as he could, with his head cast down, the comments of a hundred vagabonds, who guessed the destination of the gibbets, and were escorting them to the Hôtel de Ville. Fouquet started. 'It is decided, you see,' said Gourville.

'But it is not done,' replied Fouquet.

'Oh, do not flatter yourself, monseigneur; if they have thus lulled your friendship and suspicions—if things have gone so far, you will be able to undo nothing.'

'But I have not given my sanction.'

'M. de Lyonne has ratified for you.'

'I will go to the Louvre.'

'Oh, no, you will not.'

'Would you advise such baseness?' cried Fouquet, 'would you advise me to abandon my friends? would you advise me, whilst able to fight, to throw the arms I hold in my hand to the ground?'

'I do not advise you to do anything of the kind, monseigneur. Are you in a position to quit the post of superintendent at this moment?'

'No.'

'Well, if the king wishes to displace you—'

'He will displace me absent as well as present.'

'Yes, but you will not have insulted him.'

'Yes, but I shall have been base; now I am not willing that my friends should die; and they shall not die!'

'For that it is necessary you should go to the Louvre, is it not?'

smile played round his lips; but the observer might soon have remarked that this fire and this smile applied to nothing, enlightened nothing. Vatel laughed like an absent man, and amused himself like a child. At the sound of his master's voice he turned round, exclaiming: 'Oh! monseigneur!'

'Yes, it is I. What the devil are you doing here, Vatel? Wine! You are buying wine at a cabaret in the Place de Grève!'

'But, monseigneur,' said Vatel, quietly after having dared a hostile glance at Gourville, 'why am I interfered with here? Is my cellar kept in bad order?'

'No, certes, Vatel, no; but—'

'But what?' replied Vatel. Gourville touched Fouquet's elbow.

'Don't be angry, Vatel; I thought my cellar—your cellar—sufficiently well stocked for us to be able to dispense with recourse to the cellar of "L'Image-de-Notre-Dame."'

'Eh, monsieur,' said Vatel, shrinking from monseigneur to monsieur with a degree of disdain: 'your cellar is so well stocked that when certain of your guests dine with you they have nothing to drink.'

Fouquet, in great surprise, looked at Gourville. 'What do you mean by that?'

'I mean that your butler had not wine for all tastes, monsieur; and that M. de la Fontaine, M. Pélisson, and M. Conrart, do not drink when they come to the house—these gentlemen do not like strong wine. What is to be done, then?'

'Well, and therefore?'

'Well, then, I have found here a vin de Joigny, which they like. I know they come here once a week to drink at the "Image-de-Notre-Dame." That is the reason I am making this provision.'

Fouquet had no more to say; he was convinced. Vatel, on his part, had much more to say, without doubt, and it was plain he was getting warm. 'It is just as if you would reproach me, monseigneur, for going to the Rue Planche Milbray, to fetch, myself, the cider M. Loret drinks when he comes to dine at your house.'

'Loret drinks cider at my house!' cried Fouquet, laughing.

'Certainly he does, monsieur, and that is the reason why he dines there with pleasure.'

Chapter LVIII

Epicureans



s Fouquet was giving, or appearing to give, all his attention to the brilliant illuminations, the languishing music of the violins and hautboys, the sparkling sheaves of the artificial fires, which, inflaming the heavens with glowing reflections, marked behind the trees the dark profile of the donjon of Vincennes; as, we say, the superintendent was smiling on the ladies and the poets, the fête was every whit as gay as usual; and Vatel, whose restless, even jealous look, earnestly consulted the aspect of Fouquet, did not appear dissatisfied with the welcome given to the ordering of the evening's entertainment. The fireworks over, the company dispersed about the gardens and beneath the marble porticoes with the delightful liberty which reveals in the master of the house so much forgetfulness of greatness, so much courteous hospitality, so much magnificent carelessness. The poets wandered about, arm in arm, through the groves; some reclined upon beds of moss, to the great damage of velvet clothes and curled heads, into which little dried leaves and blades of grass insinuated themselves. The ladies, in small numbers, listened to the songs of the singers and the verses of the poets; others listened to the prose, spoken with much art, by men who were neither actors nor poets, but to whom youth and solitude gave an unaccustomed eloquence, which appeared to them better than everything else in the world. 'Why,' said La Fontaine, 'does not our master Epicurus descend into the garden? Epicurus never abandoned his pupils; the master is wrong.'

'Monsieur,' said Conrart, 'you yourself are in the wrong persisting in decorating yourself with the name of an Epicurean; indeed, nothing here reminds me of the doctrine of the philosopher of Gargetta.'

'Bah!' said La Fontaine, 'is it not written that Epicurus purchased a large garden and lived in it tranquilly with his friends?'

'That is true.'

'Well, has not M. Fouquet purchased a large garden at Saint-Mande, and do we not live here very tranquilly with him and his friends?'

'Yes, without doubt; unfortunately it is neither the garden nor the friends which constitute the resemblance. Now, what likeness is there between the doctrine of Epicurus and that of M. Fouquet?'

'This—pleasure gives happiness.'

'Next?'

'Well, I do not think we ought to consider ourselves unfortunate, for my part, at least. A good repast—vin de Joigny, which they have the delicacy to go and fetch for me from my favourite cabaret—not one impertinence heard during a supper an hour long, in spite of the presence of ten millionaires and twenty poets.'

'I stop you there. You mentioned vin de Joigny, and a good repast; do you persist in that?'

'I persist,—anteco, as they say at Port Royal.'

'Then please to recollect that the great Epicurus lived, and made his pupils live, upon bread, vegetables, and water.'

'That is not certain,' said La Fontaine; 'and you appear to me to be confounding Epicurus with Pythagoras, my dear Conrart.'

'Remember, likewise, that the ancient philosopher was rather a bad friend of the gods and the magistrates.'

'Oh! that is what I will not admit,' replied La Fontaine. 'Epicurus was like M. Fouquet.'

'Do not compare him to monsieur le surintendant,' said Conrart, in an agitated voice, 'or you would accredit the reports which are circulating concerning him and us.'

'What reports?'

'That we are bad Frenchmen, lukewarm with regard to the king, deaf to the law.'

'I return, then, to my text,' said La Fontaine. 'Listen, Conrart, this is the morality of Epicurus, whom, besides, I consider, if I must tell you so, as a myth. Antiquity is mostly mythical. Jupiter, if we give a little attention to it, is life. Alcides is strength. The words are there to bear me

Chapter LVI

M. de la Fontaine's Wine



ARRIAGES were already bringing the guests of Fouquet to Saint-Mande; already the whole house was getting warm with the preparations for supper, when the superintendent launched his fleet horses upon the roads to Paris, and going by the quays, in order to meet fewer people on the way, soon reached the Hôtel de Ville. It wanted a quarter to eight. Fouquet alighted at the corner of the Rue de Long-Pont, and, on foot, directed his course towards the Place de Grève, accompanied by Gourville. At the turning of the Place they saw a man dressed in black and violet, of dignified mien, who was preparing to stop at Vincennes. He had before him a large hamper filled with bottles, which he had just purchased at the cabaret with the sign of 'L'Image-de-Notre-Dame.'

'Eh, but! that is Varel! my maître d'hôtel!' said Fouquet to Gourville.

'Yes, monseigneur,' replied the latter.

'What can he have been doing at the sign of L'Image-de-Notre-Dame? Buying wine, no doubt.'

'What! buy wine for me, at a cabaret?' said Fouquet. 'My cellar, then, must be in a miserable condition!' and he advanced towards the maître d'hôtel, who was arranging his bottles in the carriage with the most minute care.

'*Hola!* Varel,' said he, in the voice of a master.

'Take care, monseigneur!' said Gourville, 'you will be recognized.'

'Very well! Of what consequence?—Varel!'

The man dressed in black and violet turned round. He had a good and mild countenance, without expression—a mathematician minus the pride. A certain fire sparkled in the eyes of this personage, a rather sly

out; Zeus, that is, *zen*, to live. Alcides, that is, *alce*, vigour. Well, Epicurus, that is mild watchfulness, that is protection; now who watches better over the state, or who protects individuals better than M. Fouquet does?

'You talk etymology and not morality; I say that we modern Epicureans are indifferent citizens.'

'Oh!' cried La Fontaine, 'if we become bad citizens, it is not through following the maxims of our master. Listen to one of his principal aphorisms.'

'I—will.'

'Pray for good leaders.'

'Well?'

'Well! what does M. Fouquet say to us every day? "When shall we be governed?" Does he say so? Come, Conrart, be frank.'

'He says so, that is true.'

'Well, that is a doctrine of Epicurus.'

'Yes; but that is a little seditious, observe.'

'What! seditious to wish to be governed by good heads or leaders?'

'Certainly, when those who govern are bad.'

'Patience, I have a reply for all.'

'Even for what I have just said to you?'

'Listen! would you submit to those who govern ill? Oh! it is written:

Caecos politicosi. You grant me the text?'

'*Parbleu!* I think so. Do you know, you speak Greek as well as Aesop

did, my dear La Fontaine.'

'Is there any wickedness in that, my dear Conrart?'

'God forbid I should say so.'

'Then let us return to M. Fouquet. What did he repeat to us all the day? Was it not this? "What a cuistre is that Mazarin! what an ass! what a leech! We must, however, submit to that fellow." Now, Conrart, did he say so, or did he not?'

'I confess that he said it, and even perhaps too often.'

'Like Epicurus, my friend, still like Epicurus; I repeat, we are Epicureans, and that is very amusing.'

'Yes; but I am afraid there will rise up, by the side of us, a sect like that of Epicureans; you know him well; the philosopher of Hierapolis, he who called bread luxury, vegetables prodigality, and clear water drunkenness;

he who, being beaten by his master, said to him, grumbling a little it is true, but without being angry, "I will lay a wager you have broken my leg!"—and who won his wager.'

'He was a goose, that fellow Epicurus.'

'Granted, but he might easily become the fashion by only changing his name into that of Colbert.'

'Bah!' replied La Fontaine, 'that is impossible. Never will you find Colbert in Epicurus.'

'You are right, I shall find—Coluber there, at the most.'

'Ah! you are beaten, Conrart; you are reduced to a play upon words. M. Arnaud pretends that I have no logic; I have more than M. Nicole.'

'Yes,' replied Conrart, 'you have logic, but you are a Jansenist.'

This peroration was hailed with a boisterous shout of laughter; by degrees the promenaders had been attracted by the exclamations of the two disputants around the arbour under which they were arguing. The discussion had been religiously listened to, and Fouquet himself, scarcely able to suppress his laughter, had given an example of moderation. But with the denouement of the scene he threw off all restraint, and laughed aloud. Everybody laughed as he did, and the two philosophers were saluted with unanimous felicitations. La Fontaine, however, was declared conqueror, on account of his profound erudition and his irrefragable logic. Conrart obtained the compensation due to an unsuccessful combatant; he was praised for the loyalty of his intentions, and the purity of his conscience.

At the moment when this jollity was manifesting itself by the most lively demonstrations, when the ladies were reproaching the two adversaries with not having admitted women into the system of Epicurean happiness, Gourville was seen hastening from the other end of the garden, approaching Fouquet, and detaching him, by his presence alone, from the group. The superintendent preserved on his face the smile and character of carelessness; but scarcely was he out of sight than he threw off the mask.

'Well!' said he, eagerly, 'where is Pélisson! What is he doing?'

'Pélisson has returned from Paris.'

'Has he brought back the prisoners?'

'He has not even seen the concierge of the prison.'

'What! did he not tell him he came from me?'

'No, for so it happened I had one of my men in the crowd; a new recruit from the provinces, one M. Menneville, whom I like very much. He made his way through the press, saying to the joker: "*Mille barbes!* Monsieur the false joker, here's a thrust for Colbert!" "And one for Fouquet," replied the joker. Upon which they drew in front of the cook's shop, with a hedge of the curious round them, and five hundred as curious at the windows.'

'Well?' said Fouquet.

'Well, monsieur, my Menneville spirited the joker, to the great astonishment of the spectators, and said to the cook:—"Take this goose, my friend, for it is fatter than your fowl." That is the way, monsieur,' ended the Abbé, triumphantly, 'in which I spend my revenues; I maintain the honour of the family, monsieur.' Fouquet hung his head. 'And I have a hundred as good as he,' continued the Abbé.

'Very well,' said Fouquet, 'give the account to Gourville, and remain here this evening.'

'Shall we have supper?'

'Yes, there will be supper.'

'But the chest is closed.'

'Gourville will open it for you. Leave us, monsieur l'Abbé, leave us.'

'Then we are friends?' said the Abbé, with a bow.

'Oh, yes, friends. Come, Gourville.'

'Are you going out? You will not stay to supper, then?'

'I shall be back in an hour; rest easy, Abbé.' Then aside to Gourville,—

'Let them put to my English horses,' said he, 'and direct the coachman to stop at the Hôtel de Ville de Paris.'